

who is part of our pop culture, to succeed. But for me, it is also my personal relationship with him that wants the best for him. I wanted the film to do well for him professionally as well as for his family. For a film to succeed, your intention needs to be pure. Deep down, we wished and prayed that it did well. There's no logic to this. As I was telling Shah Rukh and Gauri [his wife], these are love and blessings that are coming back.

Q. What was the atmosphere on the set like?

A. We were all very present, which is difficult to do in today's day and age with so many distractions. Yes, we were making a big action movie with an element of patriotism; so there was some amount of seriousness and responsibility, but that didn't mean we couldn't have moments of fun. When SRK and I are together, a lot of childlike moments happen. We are able to be very honest and vulnerable with each other.

Q. Apart from vulnerability, another thing you seem to have in common is how you deal with controversy. There's composure and restraint. Would you agree?

A. I can say this for the both us that we don't know any other way of being. I think that's just who we are as people and the way we have been brought up by our respective families. We came here [to Mumbai] alone with just dreams and aspirations. All we know is commitment, hard work and humility, and it has gotten us where we are. Some of it [handling adversity] comes with experience and maturity. We both have been athletes. I do know that he played sport in school and college. Sport teaches you a lot about restraint.

Q. Did it help in dealing with the brouhaha before the film's release?

A. As I said, I don't know any other way. It comes across as not reacting. But shutting out the noise comes from knowing your truth and just having patience, resilience and humility.

Q. At 57, Khan has performed stunts, built a body and given the biggest hit of his career. What are some of the lessons actors can learn from his example?

A. Apart from the resilience, patience, humility and restraint, his generosity as a co-star. I have yet to come across an actor as generous as him. He understands what is important for a film, and that for a film to work, everyone needs to succeed. Nobody understands and executes it better than him. ■

resist fever-pitch jingoism to promote goodwill and communal harmony. The movie's plot even has a female ISI spy (Deepika Padukone), who wins audience support for helping Pathaan battle an over-ambitious Pakistani general. At Land's End, SRK used the composition of the movie's cast to remind audiences that India's diversity and its secular fabric are its biggest strength. He said, "This is Deepika, she is Amar, I'm Shah Rukh Khan, I'm Akbar and John, he is Anthony... We are 'Amar, Akbar, Anthony'. And this is what makes cinema... There are no differences any one of us have with any culture. We are hungry for audience's love."



"Raj and Rahul [his earlier characters] have taken a backseat, he is now Pathaan for everybody"

–SIDDHARTH ANAND
Director, Pathaan

Overall, though, it is Khan's compelling performance as a vulnerable action hero that holds the movie together and wins the day. The film is mindful of Khan's female fan base and never makes his masculinity toxic. Pathaan's Achilles' heel, we are told, is that he listens to his heart and pays a price for it. "When you think of SRK, you think of love," says *Pathaan* director Siddharth Anand. "Pathaan had to be a guy who is heart over mind any day. It is a reflection of what he is in real life." Simultaneously, he appeals to the frontbenchers, giving them a soldier who serves the nation that raised him. Pathaan is not a one-man army and invincible; he, in fact, needs rescuing—by Padukone and Salman Khan's Tiger—as well as painkillers.

Part of the film's appeal also lies in how much audiences are reading into the film's dialogues, which are laden with references to his own past. Much like the broken spy whose body is held together with "biodegradable screws", Khan has also undergone surgeries on his back, shoulder and knee. Again, like Pathaan, Khan too was written off only to rise again and save the day. It's why the reference to 'kintsugi', a traditional Japanese pottery repair technique in which cracks are filled and missing pieces replaced with lacquer mixed with powdered gold, sits well